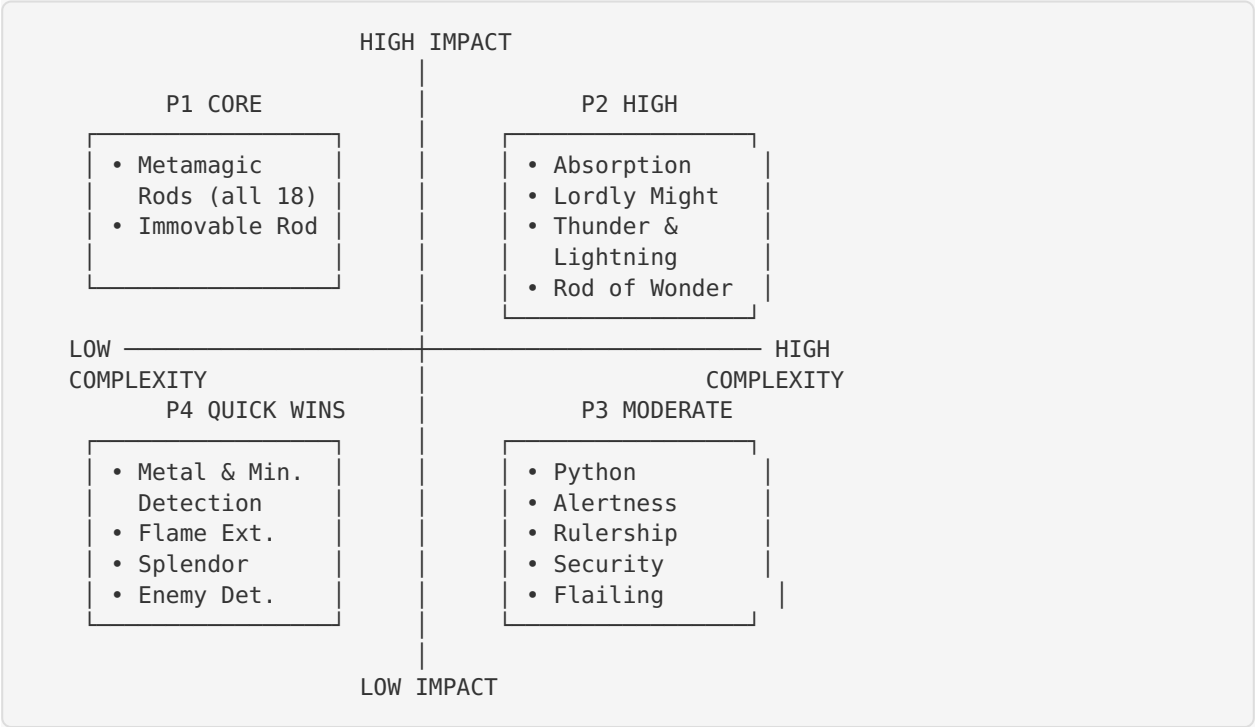


D&D 3.5e Rods — Priority Matrix (Impact vs. Complexity)

Companion to: rods_implementation_plan.md
Purpose: Rank all 36 rod items by gameplay impact and implementation complexity
Date: May 2026

Priority Matrix Visualization



Priority Tiers

P1 — CORE (Build First) ●

These are foundational or high-frequency items that define the rod category.

Rod	Price	Impact	Complexity	Rationale
Immovable Rod	5,000 gp	★★★★★	★☆☆☆☆	Most iconic rod in D&D. Simple to implement. Used constantly by creative players. High visibility, low effort.
Metamagic Rods (all 18)	3,000–170,000 gp	★★★★★	★★★★☆	Core spellcaster mechanic. Every caster wants one. 18 variants from one shared system. High ROI.

Estimated effort: 2 weeks

Value delivered: ~53% of all rod items (19 of 36)

P2 — HIGH PRIORITY

High gameplay impact but require dedicated complex systems.

Rod	Price	Impact	Complexity	Rationale
Rod of Cancellation	11,000 gp	★★★★☆	★☆☆☆☆	Unique “destroy magic item” mechanic. One-use makes it simple. Dramatic gameplay moments.
Rod of Negation	37,000 gp	★★★★☆	★☆☆☆☆	Counter-magic utility. Dispel magic items 3/day. Straightforward ray attack.
Rod of Withering	25,000 gp	★★★★☆	★☆☆☆☆	Ability damage weapon (STR + CON). Builds on existing ability damage system.
Rod of the Viper	19,000 gp	★★★☆☆	★☆☆☆☆	+2 heavy mace with poison. Needs alignment check system.
Rod of Flailing	50,000 gp	★★★☆☆	★★★☆☆	Weapon transformation + defensive buff. Two separate systems.
Rod of Absorption	50,000 gp	★★★★★	★★★★☆	Novel spell absorption mechanic. Integrates with spell slot economy. Complex state.
Rod of Lordly Might	70,000 gp	★★★★★	★★★★★	Most complex item in the game. 4 weapon forms + 3 spell-like + utility. Showcase item.

Estimated effort: 2.5 weeks

Value delivered: +7 rods (total: 26 of 36)

P3 — MODERATE PRIORITY

Good gameplay value, moderate complexity. Fun but not essential.

Rod	Price	Impact	Complexity	Rationale
Rod of Wonder	12,000 gp	★★★★☆	★★★★☆	20 random effect categories. Enormous fun factor. Implementation is wide (many effects) rather than deep.
Rod of Thunder & Lightning	33,000 gp	★★★★☆	★★★★☆	5 distinct combat abilities. Multiple damage types. Combined attack mode.
Rod of Python	13,000 gp	★★★☆☆	★★★☆☆	Creature summoning + basic AI. Reusable system for other summon items.
Rod of Alertness	85,000 gp	★★★☆☆	★★★☆☆	Many abilities but each is simple. Good passive bonuses. 8 detect spells at-will.
Rod of Rulership	60,000 gp	★★★☆☆	★★★☆☆	Mass charm. Needs mass save system. 500-minute total usage tracking.

Estimated effort: 2 weeks

Value delivered: +5 rods (total: 31 of 36)

P4 — LOWER PRIORITY

Niche utility or minimal combat impact. Implement last or defer.

Rod	Price	Impact	Complexity	Rationale
Rod of Metal & Mineral Detection	10,500 gp	★★☆☆☆	★☆☆☆☆	Niche exploration tool. Simple scan mechanic.
Rod of Enemy Detection	23,500 gp	★★☆☆☆	★★☆☆☆	Detect hostiles. Useful but not exciting. May duplicate existing detection spells.
Rod of Flame Extinguishing	15,000 gp	★★☆☆☆	★★☆☆☆	Charge-based fire suppression. Very situational.
Rod of Splendor	25,000 gp	★★☆☆☆	★☆☆☆☆	+4 CHA passive (easy). Apparel/tent abilities are mostly narrative.
Rod of Security	61,000 gp	★★☆☆☆	★★★★☆	Safe demiplane. Mostly narrative/non-combat. 200 person-day tracking.

Estimated effort: 1 week

Value delivered: +5 rods (total: 36 of 36, 100%)

Impact Scoring Criteria

Score	Meaning	Examples
★★★★★	Game-changing. Every party wants this.	Metamagic rods (core caster boost), Immovable Rod (universally iconic)
★★★★☆	Highly useful. Frequently chosen.	Rod of Absorption (spell defense), Rod of Wonder (massive fun)
★★★☆☆	Solid utility. Good for specific builds.	Rod of Python (summoner), Rod of Flailing (martial)
★★☆☆☆	Niche or situational.	Rod of Flame Extinguishing, Rod of Metal Detection
★☆☆☆☆	Rarely relevant.	— (no rods rated this low)

Complexity Scoring Criteria

Score	Meaning	What's Involved
★☆☆☆☆	Trivial	Single flag toggle or stat modifier
★★☆☆☆	Simple	One active ability, basic daily tracking
★★★☆☆	Moderate	Weapon transformation, creature AI, or mass-target effects
★★★★☆	Complex	Multiple distinct systems, ~20 sub-effects, or novel mechanics
★★★★★	Very Complex	6+ modes, combines weapon/spell/utility systems

Cumulative Progress Projection

End of Week	Rods Complete	% of Total	Cumulative Items
1	1 (foundation)	3%	Immovable Rod
2	19	53%	+ 18 Metamagic Rods
3	24	67%	+ Cancellation, Negation, Withering, Viper, Flailing
4	26	72%	+ Absorption, Lordly Might
5	28	78%	+ Wonder, Thunder & Lightning
6	31	86%	+ Python, Alertness, Rulership
7	34	94%	+ Detection rods, Flame Ext., Splendor
7.5	36	100%	+ Security, Enemy Detection

Risk Assessment

Risk	Likelihood	Impact	Mitigation
Metamagic system scope creep	Medium	High	Lock scope to 6 core types, no homebrew
Rod of Wonder effect bugs	High	Medium	Implement effects incrementally, test each
Lordly Might mode-switching bugs	Medium	Medium	Use state machine pattern, extensive tests
Absorption + spell system integration	Medium	High	Design clean interface between systems
Python creature AI issues	Medium	Low	Keep AI simple: follow, attack target
Save/load state corruption	Low	High	Comprehensive serialization tests early

Dependencies on Existing Systems

Rod	Required Existing System	Status
Metamagic Rods	Spell casting system	✓ Exists
Withering, Viper	Ability damage system	✓ Exists (from poisons)
Flailing	Weapon transformation	⚠ Needs extension
Python	Creature summoning + AI	⚠ Needs new system
Absorption	Spell interception hooks	✗ New system needed
Lordly Might	Multi-form weapon system	✗ New system needed
Wonder	~20 spell effect implementations	⚠ Partially exists
Cancellation	Magic item property removal	⚠ Needs extension
Rulership	Mass charm/save system	⚠ Partially exists

Summary

Metric	Value
Total rods to implement	36
P1 Core items	19 (53%)
P2 High priority	7 (19%)
P3 Moderate priority	5 (14%)
P4 Lower priority	5 (14%)
New systems required	6
Existing systems to extend	4
Total estimated time	7.5 weeks
Highest ROI item	Immovable Rod (iconic, trivial to build)
Highest ROI system	Metamagic Rod System (18 items from 1 system)